



LETTER TO THE EDITOR

Imaginal research for unlearning mastery divination with Tarot as a decolonizing methodology, NOT. Authentic paths towards decolonization

Abstract

A recent article in *Anthropology of Consciousness* entitled 'Imaginal research for unlearning mastery: Divination with Tarot as a decolonizing methodology' argues that the Western Tarot may be a useful tool to facilitate decolonization despite (or perhaps in spite) of the colonial and imperial imprints of the accumulating class. This response points out the Tarot is in fact a tool developed by the accumulating class, designed specifically to facilitate the imposition of elite master narratives. This letter calls into question the appropriateness and effectiveness of using the Tarot as a tool for decolonization.

A fascinating recent article in *Anthropology of Consciousness* entitled 'Imaginal Research for Unlearning Mastery: Divination With Tarot as a Decolonizing Methodology' (Greenberg, 2023) explores the Western Tarot, sometimes called the 'Devil's picture book', specifically the *Tarot de Marseilles*, as a possible tool for decolonization, one that can provide a 'decolonizing methodology' that can help us heal from the damage caused by colonial mental models. While the author admits that the Tarot deck has a colonial and imperial imprint (it was probably used to describe court politics and court life (Farley, 2009)) and might therefore be called the 'master's picture book', nevertheless they justify its use by suggesting that if one moves 'beyond the intentions of authorship' it can lead to emancipation (i.e. removal of the master's mental chains).

When reading the article, the question that immediately popped into our minds was, is this actually possible? Can one use a picture book designed for an elite mileaux to decolonize one's thinking and behaviour? If the author is correct and the cards are just 'objects', then maybe all the potential mechanisms that they suggest are in operation to facilitate this decolonization might lead, more or less efficiently, towards one's mental emancipation. But the cards are not just objects. They exist and are popular to this day because they are in fact part of an ideological or propaganda system intentionally designed by upper-class convective ideologists (Marx, 1978) (whom we would call System Architects) working in Freemason temples with the explicit purpose of manipulating human thought and behaviour in a way that enables and supports their colonial and capitalist ends (Sosteric, 2014). We would not be the first to say this. As foremost Tarot historians Decker, Depaulis & Dummett point out, the Tarot is the

...most successful propaganda campaign ever launched: not by a very long way the most important, but the most completely successful. An entire false history,

and false interpretation, of the Tarot pack was concocted by the occultists; and it is all but universally believed.

(Decker et al., 1996, 27)

As such, the Tarot is part of what Marx called the Means of Mental Production (Marx, 1978). To be clear, the Tarot is a sophisticated and powerful device, one among many other sophisticated and powerful devices, used to install a particularly colonial and imperial master narrative (Halverson et al., 2011), a narrative which we might call the 'master's narrative' or 'master story' (Ellens, 2014). This violent narrative was intentionally designed to nurture, enable and reproduce the predatorial capitalist regime of accumulation by manipulating our thoughts and our behaviours in a way that inserts us into the regime while also ensuring our compliant submission. To be clear, the Tarot narrative, which participates in a wider master narrative (Sosteric, Under Review), consists of archetypes and ideas which together colonize and, subsequently, constitute a particular form of being in this world.

The fact that the Tarot is a sophisticated ideological device specifically designed to colonize minds calls into question claims that one can use the tool to decolonize minds. It seems unlikely, especially when one becomes aware of the history of the deck as it passed out of the site of the masses and into the hand of Mordor, so to speak. We suggest that contrary to the author's claims, one cannot use this particular tool to decolonize minds. The tool is simply too sophisticated, too powerful and too embedded in supporting elite morphological or archetypal systems to be effective. For someone like the author who has obviously advanced a distance along the path of decolonization and can move 'beyond the intentions of authorship and capture' and can recognize and put aside the master's meanings, it *might* be useful as a creative tool that *might* be able to provide a limited and arms-length access to the spirit world through one's imagination; however, for the average person on the street who has been victimized by generations of indoctrination and toxic socialization, and who is completely unaware of the status of Tarot as an ideological weapon of the ruling class, it will likely do nothing but reproduce and reinforce the master's narrative.

If one is seeking tools to expand imagination and insight by opening channels to 'more-than-human-agency' (Greenberg, 2023), if one really wants to develop effective and not pre-colonized decolonizing methodologies, what one *really* needs is to develop new tools that are completely absent of the colonizer's imprint. We have been developing such a tool, which we call the Triumph of Spirit Archetype System (TOSAS). This is a system of 22 archetype cards. Archetype cards (or 'keys' as they are sometimes called by esotericists (Cicero & Cicero, 1996)) are playing card-size images that convey an archetype. Archetypes are conscious or unconscious ideas or concepts that provide answers to big questions. Big questions are existential questions, like 'Who am I', 'Why am I here' and 'What is my purpose'. Archetype cards, like the cards in the Freemason's Tarot, or the TOSAS system, provide archetypes that answer these 2021 questions, but in a particular way.

A great example of this is the 'The Fool' card from Tarot deck of prominent Freemason, A.E. Waite. This card (see Figure 1) shows a young white male about to step off a cliff with a small dog prancing at his feet. This card provides an archetype that answers the big questions 'Who am I' and 'Why am I here' by suggesting you are here on a life journey of some sort, specifically a 'deep spiritual journey' (Pollack, 1980, 155) with many karmic or 'life lessons' (Biddy, 2017) along the way. In this card, the 'fool' is about to step off the cliff and embark on a journey which may 1 day lead, if they learn all their lessons, towards individual perfection (Zalewski & Zalewski, 2008), salvation, celebration or maybe just a seat at a table 'higher up', as indicated in the 21st archetype of the Rider-Waite deck, 'The World' (is now your oyster) card (see Figure 2).

You can see this 'fool in school' archetype represented quite clearly in the Fool archetype card from the Rider-Waite deck. In that card, we see a literal fool stepping off a cliff



FIGURE 1 The Fool. Freemason's Fool in School Archetype (Rider-Waite tarot images are in public domain https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/Category:Rider-Waite_tarot_deck).

on their way to their earthly school where they will spend a lifetime learning their lessons and paying off their karmic debt. Commentaries on this card typically describe the fool's journey as a journey of karmic repentance, education and evolution, a journey where you are bound to mess up and make mistakes but where, if you are lucky, you will attain perfection, reach nirvana and maybe even have a graduation party, like the celebration represented in the World card (see Figure 2). The description provided by the Bidly Tarot website provides an exquisite restatement of the fool's answer to the big questions 'who am I?' and 'why am I here?'



FIGURE 2 The World. Freemason's World Archetype (Rider-Waite tarot images are in public domain https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/Category:Rider-Waite_tarot_deck).

On the Fool Tarot card, a young man stands on the edge of a cliff, without a care in the world, as he sets out on a new adventure. He is gazing upwards toward the sky (and the Universe) and is seemingly unaware that he is about to skip off a precipice into the unknown. Over his shoulder rests a modest knapsack containing everything he needs – which isn't much (let's say he's a minimalist). The white rose in his left hand represents his purity and innocence. And at his feet is a small white dog, representing loyalty and protection, that encourages him to charge forward and *learn the lessons he came to learn*. The mountains behind the Fool symbolise the challenges yet to come. They are forever present,

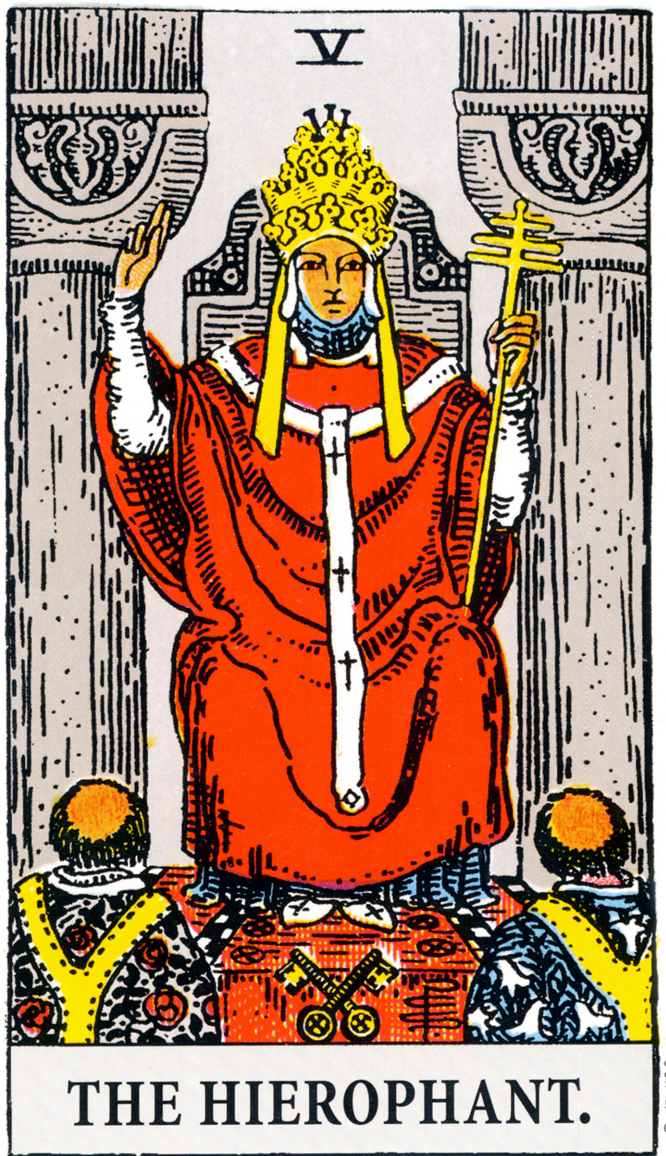


FIGURE 3 The Hierophant. Freemason's Hierophant Archetype (Rider-Waite tarot images are in public domain https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/Category:Rider-Waite_tarot_deck).

but the Fool does not care about them right now; he's more focused on starting his expedition.

(Biddy Tarot 2017, italics added)

Note that this 'fool in school' archetype is not just represented in the Tarot. You find this idea that we are all here to learn lessons in an effort to reach some future state of redemption or spiritual/evolutionary perfection everywhere. You find it in ancient Greek mythology, in the *Odyssey* where Odysseus embarks on a long and perilous journey filled with life trials, tests and lessons (Homer, 2003). In the Orphic Mysteries, the 'soul is therefore a fallen angel doing penance for her sins. Her ultimate aim is to be released from her chains and



FIGURE 4 Joyful. Triumph of Spirit Joyful Archetype (Courtesy of Mike Sosteric).

recover the inheritance she has lost. How are the prison-bars to be removed? As we lost our freedom through sin, so we cannot hope to regain it until the stain is purged away. In Orphic language, the soul must be made pure' (Adam, 1965, 101). You find it in Western theology in the Adam and Eve story in Genesis where inherently flawed humans are presented as fools who, after failing to follow the rules, are taught a cosmic lesson by being banished to hard work and painful childbirth. You also find it in Medieval Europe, a period in Europe when kings were believed to rule by 'divine right', meaning that God had given them authority over the insubordinate children who had been ejected from said Garden (Oakley, 1988). The 'you are a fool in school' idea is also stated quite directly in Gnostic traditions where

...we are told by the 'wise' that the earth plane, our home, is a kind of school where human beings are invited to learn that they are spiritual beings with an inherited propensity for enlightenment as strong as the urge of plant leaves to seek the sun. Here, in the spiritual school of the material world, humans have the opportunity to realize the sun of their true self. The world provides a learning

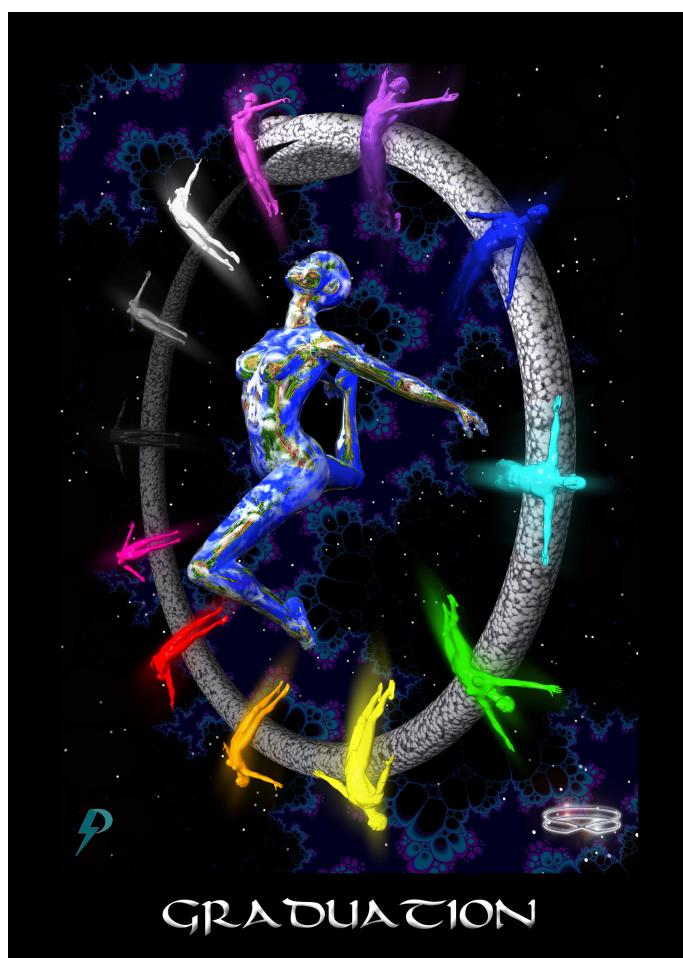


FIGURE 5 Graduation. Triumph of Spirit Graduation Archetype (Courtesy of Mike Sosteric).

space, a playground, wherein the seeker is guided through stages of an interior reconfiguration of energy.

(Yastion, 2009, quote marks added)

The idea is also found in Western esoteric traditions where it is stated most clearly of all, as for example in Theosophy where we hear that 'It is only through these births that the perpetual progress of the countless millions of Egos toward final perfection and final rest (as long as was the period of activity) can be achieved' (Blavatsky, 1889, 197–198). Antoine Faivre points out that western Esotericists 'conceive themselves as being on a pilgrimage to a higher plane of existence and an illuminated knowledge that can only be gained if the whole person is transformed' (Antoine Faivre quoted in Baier, 2021). Israel Regardie notes that his 'middle way' is all about the development of the self: 'It is the pursuit of this middle path which leads to self-conquest and the steady growth of the Golden Flower, the wakening of the imprisoned soul within' (Regardie, 2004, 9).

Unfortunately, it is not just in religious, spiritual or philosophical traditions that you find this 'fool in school' archetype. You also find it in secular culture and secular teachings. In the colonial era, we find this in the 'White Man's Burden' which is a poem that views indigenous

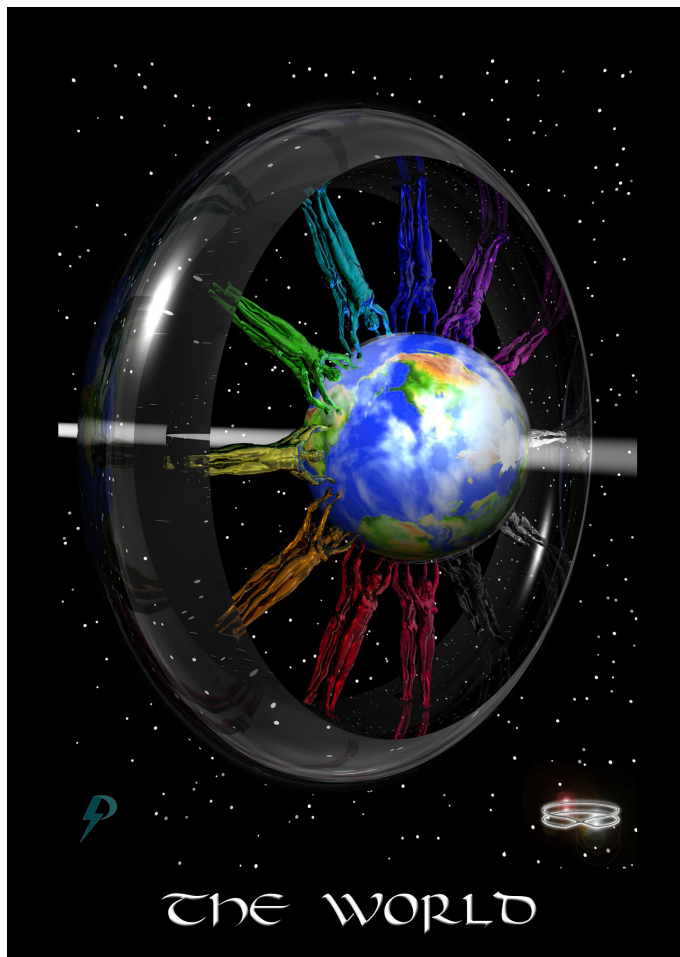


FIGURE 6 World. Triumph of Spirit Graduation Archetype (Courtesy of Mike Sosteric).

populations as uncivilized, 'half-devil' children in need of education and assistance that only white people can provide (Kipling, 1899; Said, 1979). You also find this archetype in the Industrial Revolution. This revolution brought immense hardship for workers. Here, the narrative was that hard work and suffering would eventually lead to personal or spiritual advancement and reward, so it was good to work in the factories (Hobsbawm, 1999). In modern times, you also find this idea peppered throughout the cultural landscape, for example in movies like 'The Karate Kid' (released in 1984), a story about a boy who learns all sorts of important life lessons from the wise Mr. Miyagi, or 'Billy Madison' (released in 1995), a movie about a rich adult who must repeat all 12 high-school grades within 24 weeks to prove to his father he is competent enough to inherit his hotel empire. The character is literally a 'fool in school' as he navigates the educational system to learn his lessons so he can win access to big daddy's money.

As you can see, the basic 'Fool in School' archetype is everywhere. Wherever we find it, it provides certain answers to two of life's big existential questions 'Who am I?' and 'Why am I here?' The answer provided is simple, 'You are a fool in some kind of spiritual, evolutionary school, here to learn your lessons so you can hopefully one day get into the exclusive



FIGURE 7 Emancipation. Triumph of Spirit Emancipation Archetype (Courtesy of Mike Sosteric).

“chosen boy” club’. Whether you have been exposed to Tarot or not, whether you consciously apprehend the ‘esoteric’ meaning of the Fool archetype in full we would argue, does not really matter. The archetype is in your mind whether you like it or not, and viewing the Tarot representation primes that idea in your mind. The same can be said for all the other powerful archetypes in the Freemason’s deck.

There is a lot more to say about the Fool in School archetype, like how this ancient archetype has been passed down through the ages, how it constitutes a person as someone in need of growth and development, how it sets us on a neo-liberal lesson path were we pass individual tests leading to individual achievement and individual reward, how it facilitates the subjectification of a person (McHoul & Grace, 1993), how it works with other archetypes (like the suit cards which portray elite authority or the Hierophant card (see Figure 3) which emphasizes supplication and submission) to inscribe submission and authority, and how this is just one powerful archetype in an elite-designed deck containing many powerful, elite generated, archetypes; but all that is a story for another day. Here, we would just ask the question: ‘Really?’ Can a deck of images used to colonize our thinking really be used to decolonize our thinking?

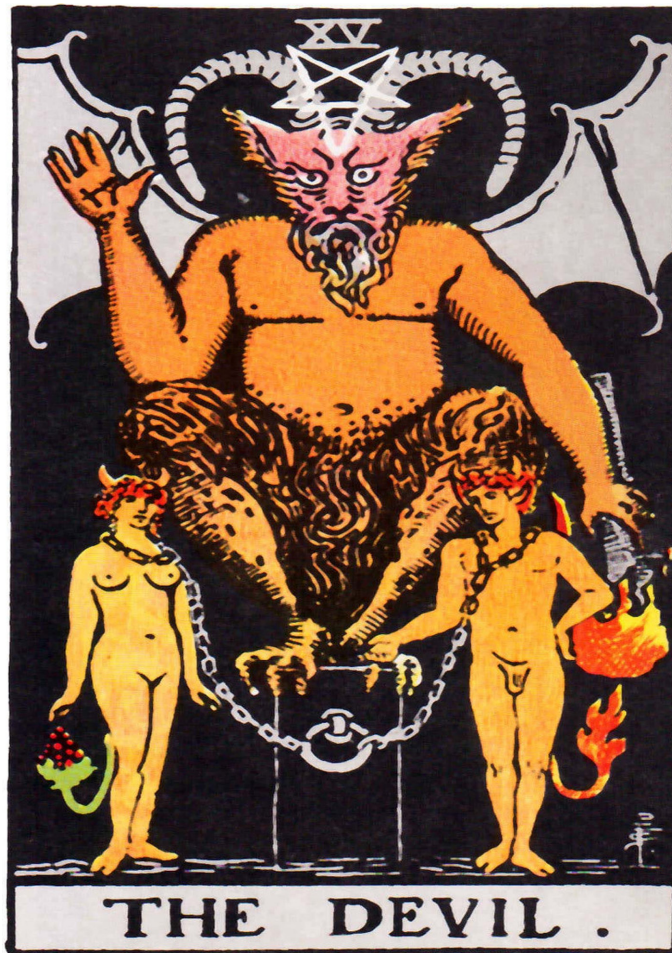


FIGURE 8 The Devil. Freemason's Devil Archetype (Rider-Waite tarot images are in public domain https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/Category:Rider-Waite_tarot_deck).

Considering the history of the Tarot and its intended use, we think not. We think that the master's archetypes from the master's picture book are so deeply ingrained and so often reinforced in every aspect of modern human life that using the images reinforces the archetype no matter how much you might resist. We think it is naive to assume that persons in search of meaning, or some sort of real change, will find answers or see 'the wisdom' while using tools designed to invoke and reinforce a colonial mindset. We also think that if we, as individuals and as a collective, are serious about decolonizing, then we need to stop uncritically accepting the accumulating class's¹ master narrative and immediately halt the use of their tools. Instead, we need to develop and (equally importantly) support the development of new narratives and new tools. We have been working on a new narrative and a new system. We call it the Triumph of Spirit Narrative and the Triumph of Spirit Archetype System. The TOS narrative and system are intentionally designed as subversive replacements to the narrative and Tarot systems provided by conceptive ideologists working with/loyal to the accumulating class, in Freemason lodges and elsewhere. This narrative and system is presented in a small deck of 22 archetype cards, the Triumph of Spirit Archetype Deck.

We are not going to say much about the TOS narrative or the TOS system here, because it is still under development. You can get a flavour for the system by considering the first card in the deck, the *Joyful* card (see Figure 4). This card, which is intended as a subversion of the elite's neo-liberal 'fool' archetype, shows a powerful, connected, confident, highly intelligent and empathic being entering into incarnation *not* to work long hours or engage in struggles to learn life lessons, but to enjoy life, play and be joyful. The Joyful archetype from the Triumph of Spirit Archetype system presents a narrative that encourages a less individualistic, less narcissistic, less neo-liberal, less labour-oriented way of thinking about and being in the world, one that, along with other archetypes in the deck, teaches we are not here to work and labour and achieve, but to relax and play and have fun. One that, with the help of other archetypes in the deck, emphasizes collective responsibility, collective achievement and collective success. In this regard, consider the final archetype in the TOS deck, *Graduation* (see Figure 5), which shows, along with the associated *World* card from the TOS deck (see Figure 6), a collective success that comes after our collective work (on ourselves and the whole world) is complete.

Note the multiple figures and rainbow colours. This symbolizes an inclusive, non-binary, culturally and ethnically inclusive take on humanity and a collective, not individual, take on purpose. You find no authority figures in the TOSAS deck, no emperors or empresses, no court figures and no supplication. The TOSAS decolonizes. The TOSAS emancipates (see Figure 7). The Masonic Master's Tarot does not.

In closing, we would just like to say that if one persists in attempts to decolonize the colonized mind with tools designed by the colonizer to colonize the uncolonized mind, at the very least one should familiarize themselves with the embedded narrative (Sosteric, Under Review) so that one can fully confront and subvert that narrative, something the author does in fact successfully do, probably because they have already achieved a certain decolonization, but who might do much better if better informed. Having fully confronted that narrative, one should also warn readers of the nature of the tool and potential dangers of use; otherwise, one might become complicit in the propagation of elite master narratives explicitly designed, as indicated by the Devil Card (see Figure 8) from the Devil's picture book, to diminish and enslave.

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ENDNOTE

- ¹ The accumulating class is the class that, through various means and mechanisms, accumulates abstracted labour time (Sosteric, 2016). It is a term for the 0.01%... the bourgeoisie. This term focuses specifically on their primary goal of this class which is unlimited and unfettered accumulation of labour time.

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